Haystack user manual

Haystack finds files and folders on your Mac by name. It shows results while you type. It also shows how much disk space each folder uses. This manual tells you how to install Haystack, give it access, find files, write queries, and see disk use. Section 11 tells you what to do when a result is wrong.

The text uses ASD-STE100 rule categories for plain language: active voice, one instruction per step, short sentences, and one term for one thing. It is not an official ASD-STE100 compliance certificate.

1. Safety and scope

- Haystack reads the names, sizes, and dates of files. It does not read the contents of files.
- Haystack keeps the index on your Mac. It does not send the index or your queries to a network.
- Haystack does not change an item, except when you use **Move to Trash**.
- Haystack sends names and paths to other apps only when you ask. See section 10.

> **WARNING: Move to Trash** moves all selected items to the Trash immediately. Haystack does not ask you to confirm. Make sure that you selected only the items that you want to remove.

> **NOTE:** To get an item back from the Trash, open the Trash in Finder. Then select the item and choose **File > Put Back**.

2. Terms

This manual uses these terms. Each term has one meaning only.

Term	Meaning
Index	The list of all file and folder names that Haystack keeps. Haystack updates it while you work.
Item	One file or one folder in the index.
Query	The text that you type in the search field.
Term	One word of a query. A space separates two terms.
Result	An item that matches the query.
Modifier	A word with a colon that changes how a term matches, for example `case:`.
Function	A word with a colon that tests a property of an item, for example `size:`.

Search mode	The view that shows results in a list.
Tree mode	The view that shows all folders as an outline, with the size of each folder.
Disk Map	The view that shows each file as a rectangle. A large rectangle is a large file.
Full Disk Access	A macOS permission. It lets Haystack see protected folders, for example Mail.
Status bar	The line of text at the bottom of the window.
Path	The location of an item, for example `/Users/ana/Documents/report.pdf`.

3. Install Haystack

3.1 Install from the App Store

1. Open the App Store.
2. Search for **Haystack: File Search**.
3. Click **Get**.
4. Open Haystack from the Applications folder.
5. Do the procedure in section 4.1.

3.2 Install from a disk image

1. Open the file `Haystack-<version>.dmg`.
2. Drag **Haystack** to the **Applications** folder.
3. Open Haystack from the Applications folder.
4. Do the procedure in section 4.2.

4. Give Haystack access

Haystack can find only the items that it can see. Do the procedure for your edition.

4.1 App Store edition

The first time that Haystack opens, it asks which disk to index.

1. Make sure that **Macintosh HD** is selected. This lets Haystack index all of your Mac.
2. Click **Grant Access**.
3. Wait while Haystack indexes the disk. The status bar shows `indexing…` and a count.
4. Do the procedure in section 4.3 to include protected folders.

> **NOTE:** To index a different disk or folder, select it in step 1 instead of **Macintosh HD**.

> **NOTE:** If you click **Cancel**, Haystack closes. Haystack asks again the next time that it opens.

4.2 Disk image edition

Haystack indexes all of your Mac when it opens for the first time. It does not ask which disk to use.

1. Wait while Haystack indexes the disk. The status bar shows `indexing…` and a count.
2. Do the procedure in section 4.3.

4.3 Give Full Disk Access

Without Full Disk Access, Haystack cannot see some folders, for example Mail, Messages, and Safari. The button **Grant Full Disk Access...** shows at the right end of the status bar until you give access.

1. Click **Grant Full Disk Access...**. System Settings opens at **Privacy & Security > Full Disk Access**.
2. Find **Haystack** in the list.
3. Turn on the switch next to **Haystack**.
4. Type your Mac password if macOS asks for it.
5. Go back to Haystack.

Haystack then adds the protected folders to the index. You do not have to do anything.

> **NOTE:** If you gave Haystack access to one folder only, and that folder does not contain your Library folder, Haystack does not need Full Disk Access. The button does not show.

5. Find an item

1. Click **Search** at the top of the window, or press **⌘F**.
2. Type part of the name of the item.
3. Read the results. Haystack updates the results after each key.
4. Press ↓ to move from the search field to the results.
5. Select a result.
6. Do one of the tasks in this table.

Task	Action
Open the item	Press **Return**, press **⌘O**, or double-click the result.
Show the item in Finder	Choose **File > Reveal in Finder** (**⌘R**).
Copy the name	Choose **Edit > Copy** (**⌘C**).

Copy the path	Choose **Edit > Copy Full Path** (⇧⌘**C**).
Move the item to the Trash	Read the WARNING in section 1. Then choose **File > Move to Trash** (⌘**Delete**).
Copy the item to a different app	Drag the result to that app or to a Finder window.

> **NOTE:** Right-click a result to see the same tasks in a menu.

The **Path** column shows the folder that holds the item. The **Size** column is empty for folders. To see the size of a folder, use Tree mode (section 7) or the Disk Map (section 8).

5.1 Sort the results

1. Click a column header: **Name**, **Path**, **Size**, or **Date Modified**.
2. To reverse the order, click the same header again.

The first click on **Size** or **Date Modified** shows the largest or the newest items first.

5.2 Read the status bar

The status bar shows the number of results, for example `1,204 objects`. It also shows these messages:

Message	Meaning
`loading index…`	Haystack reads the saved index. This takes a short time after Haystack opens.
`indexing…`	Haystack makes the index. Results can be incomplete until this message goes away.
`Match Case`	Haystack matches upper case and lower case exactly. See section 6.4.
`Match Path`	Haystack matches each term against the full path. See section 6.4.

6. Write a query

6.1 Basic rules

- Haystack finds a term anywhere in a name. `report` finds `Annual report.pdf`.
- Haystack ignores upper case and lower case. `REPORT` and `report` find the same items.
- Haystack treats accented letters as different letters. `café` does not find `cafe`.
- Haystack finds a letter with an accent, however the name of the item stores that letter.

6.2 Operators

Operator	To find	Example

space	Items that contain all terms (AND)	`invoice 2026`
`|`	Items that contain one term or the other (OR)	`jpg | png`
`!`	Items that do not contain the term (NOT)	`report !draft`
`< >`	A group of terms	`<jpg | png> holiday`
`"…"`	A term that contains a space	`"read me"`
`*`	Any number of characters. Matches the full name.	`*.swift`
`?`	One character. Matches the full name.	`IMG_????.heic`
`/`	A term that matches the full path	`Documents/ tax`
`~`	Your home folder	`~/Desktop/`

6.3 Functions

Function	To find	Example
`ext:`	Items with an extension. Use `;` to give more than one.	`ext:pdf;docx`
`size:`	Files of a size. Use `<`, `>`, or a range with `..`.	`size:>100mb`, `size:1mb..5mb`
`size:`	Files of a size group: `empty`, `tiny`, `small`, `medium`, `large`, `huge`, `gigantic`	`size:huge`
`dm:`	Items changed on a date or in a period	`dm:today`, `dm:lastweek`, `dm:2026-10`
`len:`	Names of a length	`len:<8`
`parent:`	Items directly in a folder (not in its subfolders)	`parent:~/Downloads`
`count:`	A maximum number of results	`count:20`

Size units are `b`, `kb`, `mb`, `gb`, and `tb`. One `kb` is 1,024 bytes. The size groups are:

- `empty`: 0 bytes.
- `tiny`: up to 10 `kb`.
- `small`: up to 100 `kb`.
- `medium`: up to 1 `mb`.
- `large`: up to 16 `mb`.
- `huge`: up to 128 `mb`.
- `gigantic`: more than 128 `mb`.

Date periods are `today`, `yesterday`, `thisweek`, `lastweek`, `thismonth`, `lastmonth`, `thisyear`, and `lastyear`. To find items changed in a recent period, type `last`, a number, and a unit, for example `dm:last3days` or `dm:last2weeks`. You can also type a date as `2026`, `2026-`

`10`, or `2026-10-05`. Use `<` or `>` before a date, for example `dm:>2026-01-01`.

6.4 Modifiers

Put a modifier before a term. The modifier applies to that term only.

Modifier	Effect
`case:`	Matches upper case and lower case exactly.
`path:`	Matches the term against the full path.
`regex:`	Reads the term as a regular expression (a pattern language for text, as in `grep`).
`ww:`	Matches whole words only.
`startwith:`	Matches names that start with the term.
`endwith:`	Matches names that end with the term.
`exact:`	Matches names that are the same as the term.
`file:`	Finds files only.
`folder:`	Finds folders only.

You can use more than one modifier on a term, for example `folder:exact:Projects`.

To apply **Match Case** or **Match Path** to the full query, use the **Search** menu (**⌥⌘C** or **⌥⌘P**).

6.5 Examples

Query	Finds
`ext:pdf dm:thisweek`	PDF files that changed this week
`folder:exact:node_modules`	Folders with the name `node_modules`
`size:gigantic !ext:dmg`	Files larger than 128 MB that are not disk images
`~/Documents/ invoice <2025 | 2026>`	Items in Documents with `invoice` and `2025` or `2026` in the name
`startwith:IMG_ ext:heic`	Photos with names that start with `IMG_`

7. See folder sizes in Tree mode

1. Click **Tree** at the top of the window.
2. Click the triangle next to a folder to show its contents.
3. Read the **Size** column. It shows the total size of all items in the folder.
4. Read the **Items** column. It shows the number of files in the folder and its subfolders.
5. To open an item, double-click it.

> **NOTE:** Right-click an item to open it, show it in Finder, copy its path, or move it to the Trash.

8. See disk use in the Disk Map

The Disk Map shows each file as a rectangle. The area of the rectangle shows the size of the file. The color shows the file type.

1. Click **Disk Map** at the top of the window.
2. Move the pointer over a rectangle. The line above the map shows the path and the size.
3. To show the contents of a folder, click it. Haystack opens the smallest folder under the pointer.
4. To go back one folder, right-click the map, or press **Esc** or **Delete**.
5. To show an item in Finder, double-click it.

9. Use Haystack from Terminal

The command `mf` is in the Haystack app. It gets results from Haystack. If Haystack is not running, `mf` starts it.

1. Open Terminal.
2. Type this command one time: `sudo mkdir -p /usr/local/bin`
3. Type this command one time to make `mf` available: `sudo ln -s /Applications/Haystack.app/Contents/MacOS/mf /usr/local/bin/mf`
4. Type `mf` and a query, for example `mf ext:pdf invoice`.

Option	Effect
`-n 20`	Shows a maximum of 20 results. Without `-n`, `mf` shows a maximum of 100,000.
`-s size`	Sorts by `name`, `path`, `size`, or `date`.
`-r`	Reverses the order.
`-p`	Matches terms against the full path.
`-c`	Matches case exactly.
`-l`	Shows the date, the size, and the path.
`--json`	Shows the results as JSON, a data format for other programs.
`--status`	Shows the state of the index.
`-h`	Shows all options and the query syntax.

10. Use Haystack with an AI assistant

Haystack can give search results to an AI assistant that uses the Model Context Protocol (MCP).

1. Do steps 1 to 3 of section 9.
2. Add an MCP server to your assistant with the command `mf --mcp`.
3. For Claude Code, type `claude mcp add haystack -- mf --mcp`.
4. Ask the assistant to find a file.

The assistant gets two tools: `search` and `status`. It can read the names, paths, sizes, and dates of items. It cannot read the contents of files through Haystack.

> **NOTE:** An assistant that runs on a server can send these names and paths to that server.

11. Troubleshooting

Problem	Possible cause	Action
There are no results.	The query is too narrow.	Remove terms one at a time.
There are no results.	Haystack is still indexing.	Wait until `indexing…` goes away.
An item in Mail, Messages, or Safari is missing.	Haystack does not have Full Disk Access.	Do the procedure in section 4.3.
An item on a different disk is missing.	Haystack indexes one disk.	App Store edition: see section 4.1. Disk image edition: Haystack indexes only the startup disk.
An item in iCloud Drive is missing.	macOS did not download the folder.	In Finder, right-click the folder and choose **Download Now**. Then choose **Haystack > Rebuild Index**.
A name with an accent is missing.	Accents are different letters.	Type the accent, for example `café`.
A new item is missing.	The index has not updated yet.	Wait a few seconds.
Results stay wrong.	The index is damaged.	Choose **Haystack > Rebuild Index**.
`mf` shows `Haystack is not running`.	Haystack did not start.	Open Haystack, then try again.

12. Keyboard shortcuts

The shortcuts act on the selected items in Search mode and Tree mode. The Disk Map has no selection.

Keys	Action
⌘F	Go to the search field.
↓	Go from the search field to the results.
⌘O	Open the selected items.
Return	Search mode: open the selected items.
⌘R	Show the selected items in Finder.
⌘C	Copy the names of the selected items.
⇧⌘C	Copy the full paths of the selected items.
⌘Delete	Move the selected items to the Trash.
⌥⌘C	Turn **Match Case** on or off.
⌥⌘P	Turn **Match Path** on or off.
Esc or **Delete**	Disk Map: go back one folder.
⌘W	Close the window.
⌘Q	Quit Haystack.